MEMORANDUM

DATE October 24, 2026
TO Winnebago County Board of Supervisors
FROM James Krauska, GIS analyst
SUBJECT Demographic and economic profile of Winnebago County, Wisconsin

Independent portfolio sample prepared from public data. Not an official Winnebago County document. Interactive version: krauskagis.com/winnebago.html

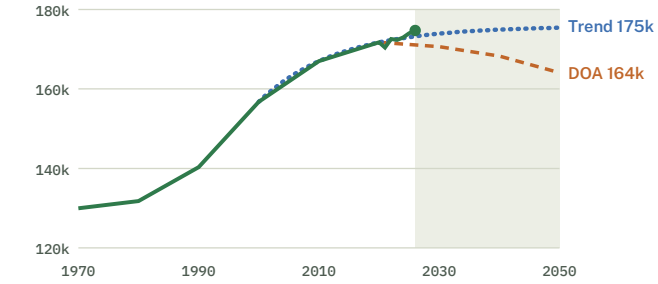
1. Population is growing slowly, entirely through migration

The Wisconsin DOA estimates 174,690 residents on January 1, 2026, up 2,960 (+1.7%) from the 2020 Census, compared with +2.9% statewide. Deaths (9,957) outnumbered births (9,667), so all of the gain came from net in-migration of 3,250 people. The Town of Clayton alone added 884 residents (+20%), about 30% of the county's growth; the City of Menasha and Town of Neenah lost population.

2. The official projection may understate the county

DOA's Vintage 2024 projection has the county falling to 164,080 by 2050, but the 2026 estimate already exceeds DOA's projection for 2030 (170,615). Trend curves fitted to the 2000–2020 censuses (modified exponential, Gompertz and logistic) level off near 175,000 and came within about 1,500 of the 2026 estimate. A stable population that is aging is a more likely planning case than decline: residents 65 and older are projected to rise from 17% to 22% of the total.

POPULATION, 1970–2050



Census and DOA estimates · Trend (2000–20 base) · DOA projection

KEY FIGURES

Residents, Jan 1, 2026	**174,690**	+1.7% since 2020
DOA projection, 2050	**164,080**	−4.5% from 2020
Age 65 and older	**17% → 22%**	2020 to 2050
Median household income	**$74,925**	WI $77,485
Median home value	**$225,800**	WI $266,500
Jobs, 2022	**119,175**	+7.7% since 2012 (BEA)
Net in-commuters	**+11,784**	54,277 in, 42,493 out

3. A manufacturing base that is shrinking, with growth elsewhere

Manufacturing provides 21,832 jobs, 18% of the county total and 2.9 times its national share (location quotient). By the excess-employment method about 18,100 jobs are basic, for an economic base multiplier of 6.6. Manufacturing lost 3,430 jobs from 2012 to 2022; shift-share attributes 5,290 of that loss to local competitive factors rather than national or industry trends. Construction (+2,787), transportation and warehousing, finance and real estate grew. The county is a regional job center: 54,277 workers commute in, mostly from Outagamie, Calumet and Fond du Lac counties, against 42,493 who commute out.

4. Housing costs less than the state average, but many renters are stretched

Housing units grew +4.6% from 2020 to 2026, faster than population. The median home value ($225,800) is 15% below the state's, and median rent is $122 a month lower, yet 41% of renter households pay 30% or more of income for housing (Wisconsin 44%).

Considerations for the Board

- Plan for a stable-to-growing population in comprehensive plan updates, using the DOA projection as a low scenario.
- Prepare for an older population: senior housing, transportation and services, especially in towns where a quarter or more of residents are already 65+.
- Coordinate workforce and transportation planning with Outagamie, Calumet and Fond du Lac counties, which supply most in-commuters.

Sources: Wisconsin DOA Demographic Services Center (final 1/1/2026 estimates; components of change; housing unit estimates; Vintage 2024 projections). U.S. BEA CAEMP25N, 2012 and 2022. U.S. Census Bureau ACS 5-year 2020–2024 and LEHD LODES 8, 2023. Methods follow UW–Stevens Point GEOG 330 extrapolation, location quotient and shift-share techniques.